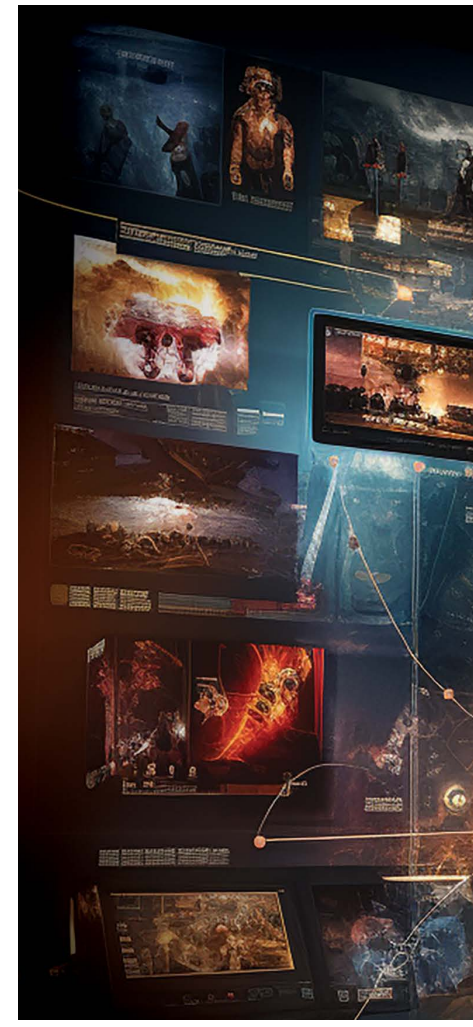
AI FILM



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WILL AI MEAN THE DEATH OF CREATIVITY?

IF AI REPLACES WRITERS, FILMMAKERS AND ARTISTS, OUR SHARED HISTORY AND HUMANITY WILL BE IN DANGER

As a science fiction filmmaker, I envisioned that AI and robots would replace the spotboys first—the so-called 'non-creative' workers on the film set. However, when the AI revolution happened, I realised that it is, in fact, primed to replace creators themselves!

I wondered if a spotboy's tasks, like serving a glass of water on a film set, are more irreplaceable than a writer's, who dreams up worlds, examines human conditions and conceives delicate emotions.

Four years ago, when I was mounting my first film, *Cargo* (currently playing on Netflix and featuring a spaceship), I encountered several financial roadblocks. One was the cost of creating the CGI for the spaceship, and the other was the expense of obtaining the one song I needed for the film. I utilised tools available today (compared to four years ago) to see what they could do. There was an app—Suno AI—into which I fed the summary of the film's story for a track that would thematically resonate with it. It spewed out a song, whose AI lyrics are such:

Cargo hawa mein, hum chadhte jaye
Aur murdon ko, hawaon se jalaaye
Aakash yatra, hamara humsafar hai
Aur duniya, aaj taklifon se bhari hai

(Cargo is in the air, we keep rising
We burn the dead with the wind
A journey through the skies, is our companion
And the world is replete with worries)

Listening to the first take was exciting, like discovering that my dog now knows the 'sit' command. But creatively, it wasn't impressive. Similarly, I asked ChatGPT to give me a thriller plot on the lines of Sriram Raghavan's stories, and it failed miserably, spewing out a mishmash of existing stories like a hacky writer would. I wondered whether the initial excitement of these tools was just limited to their newness, or whether we needed to learn a new language to talk to them to get better outputs. Later, I used various AI tools to make my posters more kinetic. When I used a poster that my graphic designer (a human) had created as an input, the AI tool gave amazing results.

I think we all were surprised to learn that AI tools